CLAUDE CODE · LIMA · SSH

Claude Code in a VM

One Linux box for PWAs, Electron and macOS apps, driven from the Claude desktop app over SSH.

github.com/prule/devvm

THE ANSWER

Run Claude Code in one Linux VM. Drive it from the desktop app over SSH.

PWAs and Electron apps run in the VM from start to finish. Only native macOS builds go back to the Mac, and only git crosses the boundary.

An agent needs a real machine, but not your Mac

SITUATION	Claude Code is most useful when it runs commands on its own: install, build, test, launch.
COMPLICATION	On the Mac it gets your whole machine. Seven devcontainers meant seven setups. One mounted container is slow and breaks file watching.
QUESTION	How does Claude get a real dev machine, separate from the Mac, without losing GUI apps or Xcode?
ANSWER	**One Lima VM, defined in one file, connected over SSH.**

Three reasons it works

Claude Code in one VM, driven over SSH. Only git crosses back to the Mac.

1 · The box

One VM is a simpler, safer box

One file, no mounts, one login.

2 · The connection

The desktop app connects over SSH

Add lima-dev, and Claude installs itself.

3 · The apps

Every kind of app has a path

PWA and Electron in the VM. macOS on the host.

POINT 1 · THE BOX

One VM is a simpler, safer box for the agent

One file

dev.yaml holds the Lima config and every provision step. No snapshots, so recovery is a rebuild from it.

Out of reach

mounts: []. Its own GitHub key. No agent forwarding. The worst case is a rebuild.

One login

Claude and gh log in once. Every devcontainer workaround is marked GONE:.

```
If something is installed in the VM and not in dev.yaml, that is a bug in dev.yaml.
```

POINT 2 · THE CONNECTION

The desktop app connects over SSH in three steps

01

./bootstrap.sh creates the VM and writes **lima-dev** to ~/.ssh/config.

02

Desktop app: environment dropdown → **Add SSH connection** → **lima-dev**.

03

On first connect, Claude Code installs itself in the VM. Gateway and VS Code use the same host.

⚠ **Port changes on restart.** Re-run ./bootstrap.sh.

⚠ **Stale session after a change.** Run ssh -O exit lima-dev.

Four things cross the boundary. Files do not.



POINT 3 · THE APPS

Every kind of app has a path. Two never leave the VM.

App	Runs in	You see it in	Tests run in
PWA	The VM	Mac browser at localhost:5173	The VM (Playwright)
Electron	The VM	Screen Sharing over VNC	The VM (xvfb-run)
macOS app	The Mac	Xcode, iOS Simulator	The Mac, code via git

Claude can build, launch and test the first two by itself. The third needs one git round trip.

PWAs run in the VM and open in the Mac browser

Ports are forwarded

Lima forwards 0.0.0.0 ports itself. dev.yaml declares the rest.

localhost is a secure context

Service workers and the install prompt behave as they do locally.

The tests stay with Claude

Playwright and Supabase in Docker both run in the VM.

```
// vite.config.ts

server: { host: true }

# dev.yaml portForwards

5173-5175 vite dev
4173 vite preview
54321-54324 supabase
```

3B · ELECTRON

Electron launches in the VM, and you watch it over VNC

Runtime libraries

GTK, X and NSS, installed explicitly.

A display for tests

Tests run under xvfb-run -a.

Sandbox stays on

One AppArmor sysctl. No --no-sandbox.

```
# in the VM
DISPLAY=:99 pnpm dev
```



```
# on the Mac: ⌘K
vnc://localhost:5901
```

3C · MACOS APP

macOS apps build on the host, and only git crosses over

VM
Claude commits

Host
git fetch vm

Host
Install, build, run

VM
Fix it here

```
# host, once per repo
git remote add vm lima-dev:projects/current/my-repo
# send a host fix back under another name
git push vm HEAD:refs/heads/from-host
```

The costs are real, and each one has a habit

Cost	What you do about it
Nothing in the VM is backed up	Push before you stop for the day
No snapshots under vz	Keep dev.yaml complete; recovery is a rebuild
No @mention of files over SSH	Attach files instead
One toolchain for every project	Renovate PRs; major bumps wait for approval

START HERE

One VM. One file. One SSH connection.

```
git clone git@github.com:prule/devvm.git && cd devvm
./bootstrap.sh
limactl shell dev -- bash /tmp/setup-github.sh
# then: desktop app → Add SSH connection → lima-dev
```

github.com/prule/devvm